

France

Competition Authority

In 2020, the Autorité decided to create a dedicated digital unit in order to strengthen its resources in digital areas. Launched in September of the same year, the digital economy unit is composed of four people (including two data scientists) and among its objectives, one of them is to develop new digital and computational tools allowing the Autorité to deepen its understanding of the digital sectors and to facilitate the work of the cases handlers.

The Autorité is proud to be part of the Stanford Computational Antitrust Project and to have contributed to its first two annual reports. The following presents what has been done since then.

As a reminder, the Autorité, in collaboration with CodeX Computational Antitrust, has published on its website the first interactive network graph tool capable of identifying within the Autorité's publications (meaning the decisions, opinions, and interim measures published between 2009 and 2021) the references to its other publications and to represent these interconnections in a graph.

An article explains all the process and the visualization tool developed by the Autorité along with the entirety of the data are accessible to all as open data on the Autorité's GitHub.

This tool has been replicated for the 3,275 merger decisions published by the French Competition Authority up to 1st January 2024. Its code is now available on the Autorité's Github.

A high-resolution image of the corresponding graph is also available here until the interactive tool is made available online.

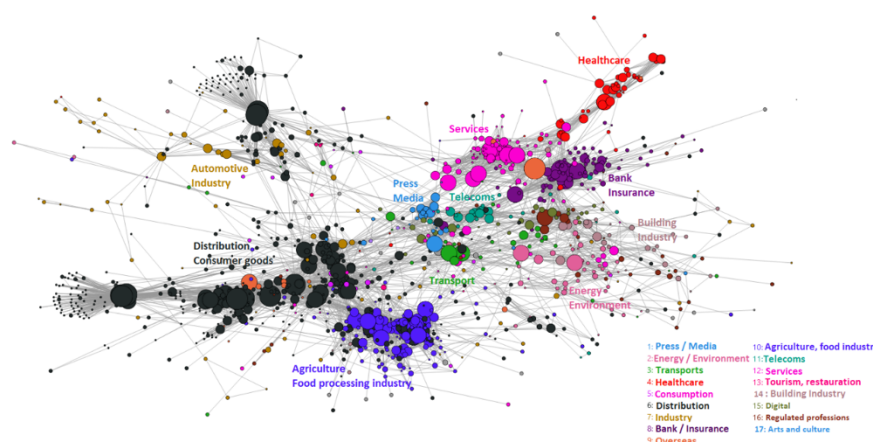


Figure I: Graph of the Autorité's merger decisions

The Autorité has also built an in-house search engine for the use of the Autorité's staff and has enriched it with the previous knowledge gained from its work described above on detecting references. The detecting tool has also been improved as it no longer only detects references to the other publications of the Autorité, but also to those of additional entities useful for our case handlers (like publications from the Commission, from French or European courts, etc.)

One example is shown below where one can see that regarding the decision 21-D-17, it quotes one decision from the Paris Court of Appeal 8 times (and the link to the decision is also provided).



Figure II: Presentation of Decision 21-D-17 in the Autorité's in-house search engine

The Autorité has also adopted an open-data approach. It has made available all its publications (in French), issued since 15 March 1988, i.e. more than 5,700 documents, available in a single database.

Under the Etalab 2.0 Open Licence, it is possible for anyone to re-use and appropriate it (for example, to power a search engine or to fine-tune a Large Language Model).

For our English readers, all the decisions, opinions, and press releases translated into English by the Autorité are also available in a single database, accessible through the QR code provided below.



Figure III: QR code to access the databases

Finally, the digital economy unit is currently developing a variety of automated tools for ongoing cases investigated by the competition units within the Autorité. We will share the technology we have developed for those cases in due course.